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# Confucianism in multicultural China: ‘official knowledge’ vs marginalised views

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## ABSTRACT

In this study, we discuss the Confucian tradition in today's multicultural China from two perspectives: that of the mandatory school curriculum, which represents ‘official knowledge’, and that of students from ethnic minority and/or religious backgrounds who are located on the cultural margins in China. The analysis draws on curricular narratives of the Confucian tradition for six major school subjects and semi-structured interviews with a group of university students from non-Han ethnic minority and/or religious backgrounds, whose lived experiences are rarely included in the national curriculum narrative. The analysis suggests that the interpretation of the Confucian tradition is a monopolising and dominant discourse that reinforces the cultural hierarchy between different cultural groups. However, the students appear to regard the Confucian tradition as only one culture and worldview in China, which can benefit from the critical reflexivity of other cultures.

## KEYWORDS

Confucianism; Confucian tradition; school curriculum; student narratives; ‘official knowledge’; nationalism; multicultural education

## 关键词

儒家传统; 学校课程; 学生话语; 官方知识; 民族主义; 多元文化教育

## 多元文化中国的儒家传统：‘官方知识’与边缘视角

在这项研究中，我们从两个角度讨论当今多元文化中国的儒家传统的教育传承问题：其一是代表‘官方知识’的学校课程的解读，以及处在中国文化边缘地带的少数民族和/或有宗教信仰背景的学生视角。数据来源主要包括六门主要学校科目的教材分析，以及对来自少数民族背景和/或宗教背景的大学生进行的半结构化访谈。已有研究证明他们的生活和文化经历会较少呈现在国家课程的叙述中。课程分析表明官方对儒家传统的阐释呈现出一种文化主导的强势话语，趋向于强化不同文化群体之间的地位差异。而学生们更倾向于把儒家传统解释为中国众多文化及世界观的一种，且认为跨文化的批判性反思会促进其发展。

## Introduction

Confucianism has experienced a revival in China since the late 1980s (Billioud and Thoraval 2015; Wang 2022). Today, Chinese students learn extensively about the Confucian tradition, particularly since the Xi Jinping government's marked promotion of traditional Chinese culture. This leads to a pressing question: How is the revived Confucian tradition

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perceived by individuals from culturally marginalised backgrounds in Chinese society? The exact nature of the 'official knowledge' (Apple 2000) presented in the school curriculum regarding the Confucian tradition remains largely unknown. It is imperative to examine whether and how such knowledge engages students in understanding China's multicultural context.

We examine Confucian education in contemporary China by comparing the curricular representation of this tradition with the views of students from non-Han minority and/or religious backgrounds, whose lived experiences are rarely included in the school curriculum (Chu 2018; Leibold and Chen 2014; Postiglione 1999; Wang and Phillion 2010; Yan and Vickers 2020, 2023; Vickers 2022; Zhao 2020). We use the term 'Confucian tradition' in this study, sometimes interchangeably with 'Confucianism', to denote *rujia*, which refers to 'a school of culture, ethics and philosophy' in the Chinese context and excludes other Chinese cultural traditions such as Daoism and Buddhism and academic traditions such as Legalism (S. Wu 2014, 947). We examine this tradition in the context of the Confucian revival in contemporary China that has been part of the resurgence of 'traditional Chinese culture' promoted by the Chinese party-state (S. Chen 2023). References to Confucianism or Confucius have rarely been included in official governmental edicts or policies, which has been portrayed as a tactic used by the government to avoid any potential ideological challenges to its socialist-communist domination (Yu 2008). However, in reality, the Confucian tradition has often been assumed to be at the core of traditional Chinese culture, representative of it and even equivalent to it, as our analysis will demonstrate.

We examine the textbooks of six school subjects that are compulsory at primary and secondary levels and reveal the party-state's discourse surrounding the interpretations of Confucian tradition through the lens of centre–margin power relations in China's cultural landscape. We conducted interviews with 37 university students from culturally marginalised backgrounds to elicit their understanding of this tradition in contemporary Chinese society. The curricular analysis and student narratives provide insights into the problems and tensions that arise from the Chinese Communist Party's (CCP) embrace of the Confucian tradition in the complex, evolving and multicultural reality of contemporary China. We refer to the cultural diversity of Chinese society as 'multicultural', emphasising its diverse ethnic and religious makeup in particular. We expose the tensions and conflicts arising from the dominant essentialist, monocultural and Han-centric conceptualisation of Chinese-ness, which has been exacerbated by the Confucian revival, and argue for educational and social inclusion, equality and justice, which constitute the essence of the multiculturalism we advocate.

We first examine the research context that addresses China's complex ethno-religious landscape and the challenges posed to non-Han and/or religious groups by standard educational practices. We situate the Confucian revival within China's centre–margin power relations and discuss the importance of examining education in or about the Confucian tradition from a multicultural perspective. We then explain our collection and analysis of data from school textbooks and students' voices, two very different sets of sources, before presenting our findings. The paper ends with a discussion of the problems, tensions and issues involved in education regarding the Confucian tradition in contemporary China.

## Ethno-religious diversity, education and the Confucian revival

China has had a richly diverse ethno-religious make-up since imperial times (Hayhoe 2018; Postiglione 1999, 2014; Vickers 2015). The Han Chinese represent about 91.11% of the national population in the People's Republic of China (PRC), and the 55 officially recognised minority nationalities comprise approximately 125 million people (National Bureau of Statistics of China 2021). Traditionally, these 'minority' groups have inhabited almost half of the national territory, and particularly the vast inner border regions (Wang 2011; Wickeri and Tam 2011). These groups have complex historical and cultural traditions. Most have their own spoken languages, and many have their own distinctive religious beliefs (Postiglione 2014; Wang 2011).

In terms of religious diversity, the Chinese state recognises five traditions as 'religions': Buddhism, Daoism, Islam, Catholicism and Protestantism; other religious practices are typically identified as folk religions or superstitions. The official census reports nearly 200 million religious believers in China, accounting for about one fifth of the national population (Chinese State Council of the PRC 2018). Religion and 'minority' identities are often closely intertwined, and the ethno-religious landscape is complicated. Ten non-Han ethnic groups are primarily Muslim; Tibetan Buddhism is practised by Tibetans and several other officially recognised minorities, most notably the Mongols; Christianity is influential among minority communities in China's northeastern and southwestern regions; Daoism is prominent amongst the Zhuang (the largest ethnic minority group), Yao and other groups; and others follow various traditional religions (Wickeri and Tam 2011). In the PRC context, the meanings of 'nationality' (*minzu*) (nowadays often translated as 'ethnicity')<sup>1</sup> and 'religion' are shaped by the party-state (Chu 2018; Leibold 2006; Mullaney et al. 2012; Postiglione 1999, 2014). The Han majority is typically constructed as 'normative' or 'invisible' (in contrast to the exoticised cultural practices of minorities) and 'modern' (modernisation being equated with secularisation in the Chinese context) (Fong and Murphy 2006; Gladney 2004; Nedostup 2009; Zhao and Postiglione 2010; Zhao 2020).

Research has shown that non-Han minority groups tend to be marginalised in Chinese society (Fong and Murphy 2006). This is manifested in the social-economic disparity between Han-dominated and predominantly minority regions, the misrepresentation of non-Han cultures as 'backward' by the Han majority and the resistance of some minority groups to using their own language as the primary medium of instruction at school (Hasmath 2019; Zhao and Postiglione 2010). J. Wu and Ingram (2019) examine the population changes of non-Han minorities based on national census data over the past six decades and show that an increasing number, particularly young people, have sought to switch their *minzu* identity to Han. This reflects the institutional obstacles that minority citizens frequently face when attempting to survive and succeed in Chinese society.

The miseducation of minority students has been well documented in academic literature published outside of mainland China. Scholars have long found a significant discrepancy between the proclaimed intentions of government policies and the experiences of minority students and their educational outcomes (Phillion and Wang 2011, 9). Although the government claims that the language and cultural rights of minority students are protected, respected and preserved, in reality, they are not. For example, Mandarin Chinese permeated Tibetan life, including the school curriculum (Nima 2001), even before the

expansion of the colonial-style boarding school system for Tibetan students analysed for this special issue by Leibold and Dorjee (2023). Han teachers' ignorance of minority students and their cultures has long been widespread, even in schools located in minority regions (Liu 2007; Qian 2007; Wang 2011). Minority cultures and knowledge are extensively under-represented or misrepresented in official school curricula (Wang and Phillion 2010; Zhao and Postiglione 2010). Phillion and Wang (2011, 9–10) argue that the cultural marginalisation of non-Han groups leads to the generally dismal state of minority students, which is characterised by the loss of their home language and culture, identity confusion, high drop-out rates and low prospects of higher education. Similarly, Yi (2008) concludes that the failure to achieve the goal of ethnic minority inclusion is largely responsible for their poor performance in terms of education and social mobility. As Yi (2008, 1) states, 'Cultural exclusion perpetuates ethnic minority inequality'; a finding that predates the Chinese state's intensified efforts under Xi Jinping to marginalise or 'museumify' minority cultures (Leibold and Dorjee 2023; Yan and Vickers 2023).

This marginalisation of minority cultures in education is closely tied to the party-state-sponsored discourse of Chinese nation-building. Leibold (2006, 22) refers to this national building process as the 'construction of a myth of national belonging rooted in the perception of a common history, soil, and blood'. Wang (2011) regards this process, which is characterised by slogans such as '56 nationalities are a family', as ideologically hegemonic, as it obscures cultural, racial and religious differences between minority groups and Han Chinese and imposes the national identity on minority people. The official vision of Chinese-ness is increasingly constructed around Han tradition and ethnicity, and the equating of ethnocultural Han-ness with Chinese-ness is being gradually embedded in public discourse, including in school curricula (S. Chen 2023; Yan and Vickers 2023; Vickers 2022, 2023). Textbooks have become more Han-centric over recent decades. For example, Yan and Vickers (2020) examine school history textbooks from the 1990s and 2000s and find that rather than exhibiting a steady progression towards greater inclusivity and a more multi-ethnic vision of Chinese-ness, they offer an increasingly Han-centric narrative of the national past. Zheng and Cherng's (2020) content analysis of 12 moral education textbooks reveals that minorities are generally under-represented and are mainly featured for their contributions to 'national unity'. The representation of Chinese culture is predominantly that of the Han (Chu 2018; Zhao and Postiglione 2010; Zheng and Cherng 2020).

Like non-Han ethnic groups, religious cultures are also typically marginalised in the public domain. The PRC Constitution grants citizens the freedom of religious belief (National People's Congress of the PRC 2004), but in reality, such freedom is limited and religious affairs are strictly controlled by the government. This situation has been exacerbated since Xi Jinping took power. Public institutions are obligated to uphold atheism, which makes it difficult to discuss, let alone teach, religion in schools (e.g. Gladney 2004; Nai et al 2020; Postiglione 1999). As Nai et al. (2020, 76) note, 'China as an atheistic state tends to marginalise the offer of religious education in general education and confines it largely to religious communities, ethnic minority regions, and religious groups and institutions'. Zhao's (2020) analysis of religious representations in Chinese school textbooks indicates that the national curriculum presents a secular understanding of the religious world and that the interpretation of religion tends to be linked to pre-modern or culturally 'backward' contexts.

The Confucian revival has occurred amid an intensification of Han-centric Chinese nation-building. Confucianism is a core feature of the wider movement for cultural revival that gathered speed after the 1989 Chinese student movement, and it has increasingly been represented as the essence of Chinese civilisation in both official and popular discourse (Wang 2022; Z. Wu and Han 2011; Z. Wu 2016; Xu and Wang 2018). This is not, however, a religious revival. Although some modern Confucian devotees have appealed to the ruling party to designate Confucianism as the state religion, such calls have proven to no avail in still officially atheistic communist China (Xu and Wang 2018). Confucianism has instead been portrayed as an indigenous cultural and ethical tradition, and it is being promoted to counteract the perceived moral blights of materialism and Westernisation, but not to compete against the official socialist-communist ideology. The ruling party has thus utilised Confucianism to attempt to neutralise its ideological crises and reinforce its political legitimacy (Wu 2014; J. Wu and Wenning 2016; Yu 2008; Zhu 2012).

Confucianism continues to enjoy state sponsorship in the Xi Jinping era, and it has become more strongly associated with revanchist nationalism. Lamenting how Chinese modernisation has been dominated by Westernisation, proponents of the Confucian revival have sought to reassert an essentialist vision of Chinese-ness (Billioud and Thoraval 2015; Jiang 2012), rooting national identity in so-called 'outstanding traditional Chinese culture' (Vickers 2022). Bolstered by economic power, China is currently showing greater confidence in projecting itself and its own perspectives and values in opposition to those of the West. Confucianism has become central to and symbolic of a uniquely 'Chinese' outlook (Cheung 2012). Internally, Confucian wisdom, said to constitute the core of the official discourse regarding China's traditional cultures, has been interpreted by and incorporated into the dominant ideology to legitimise the CCP's governance model (Kubat 2018). Externally, the Confucian tradition has been commodified for export to the outside world. Confucius Institutes help to promote the 'China Model' (Bell 2015) as the country seeks to extend its cultural soft power worldwide (Lams 2018). In parallel a range of scholars are promoting the value of Confucianism as an ethical antidote to the evils of western hegemony (see Bamberger and Morris 2023).

By situating the Confucian revival in China's complicated ethno-religious landscape and noting its co-option into the nationalist movement, we can see how it reinforces the unequal power relations in China today. The problematic Confucian ethical framework may lend itself to such co-option as it is primarily concerned with interpersonal relationships, which are viewed as family-based and hierarchical (Dikötter 2015). Domination-subordination relationships between parents and children, husbands and wives, and rulers and subjects are portrayed as normative. The goal in all of these relationships is harmony, but harmony comes from a hierarchical order that requires obedience and conformity to power. 'Democratic' conditions and dispositions of individual or group independence, freedom and equality are largely missing from the Confucian approach.

Confucian ethics have long been applied to reinforce the centre-margin power relationship. Confucian patriarchy has defined gender roles in China for centuries (Yang 2004) and the persistence of Confucian elitism has helped to maintain the socio-political hierarchy (Pines 2017). The Confucian impulse to educate and civilise the cultural other was behind the historical crusade by the Han Chinese to assimilate culturally peripheral groups (Vickers 2015). The civilising and assimilative tendency of Confucianism contributed to China's imperial expansion and the control of minority groups (Yi 2008). O'Brien

and Brown's (2022) comprehensive and devastating investigation into recent developments in Xinjiang details the Chinese government's systemic and violent attempts to Sinicise the Muslim Uyghurs. This Sinicisation process 'constructs an idealised notion of "Chinese" culture, focusing upon Han traditions, as the embodiment of both Chinese ancient "civilization" and "modernity"' (O'Brien and Brown 2022, 278). Suppressing the Uyghurs' use of their mother tongue and religious practices has become 'part of a conscious attempt to reconstruct Uyghur identity by re-orienting it towards Chinese nationalism foregrounding Han history and civilisation' (O'Brien and Brown 2022, 279). Instruction in Confucian teachings, assumed to be representative of Han tradition and culture, has been forced upon inmates in Xinjiang's so-called re-education camps. Along with praising Xi Jinping, pledging loyalty to the CCP, renouncing their religion and culture, and studying Mandarin and Han history, Uyghur detainees have been forced to memorise Confucian texts such as the *Three-Character Classic* (Finley 2019).

Confucian ethics have been criticised by many contemporary Chinese thinkers, including communists, but the CCP now appears keen to appropriate the Confucian tradition to shore up its political legitimacy. However, the intensive debates about the compatibility of the Confucian tradition with the pursuit of modernisation (e.g. Tu 1996; Van den Stock 2016; Zhu 2012) illustrate the need to critically reflect on the Confucian legacy and explore its meaning and role in contemporary society. As X. Chen (2020, 55) argues, the Confucian tradition can potentially 'become part of the cosmopolitan composition of global ethics', but this would require 'a cosmopolitan reading'.

In the remainder of this article, we deconstruct the official discourse regarding the Confucian tradition with reference to China's multicultural context and explore how non-Han minority citizens perceive the Confucian revival and its role in contemporary Chinese society. Previous studies of the representation of Confucianism in curricular discourse mainly focus on specific subjects such as Chinese language and literature (e.g. Xie et al. 2021; Zhu 2012) and rarely examine its broader role in the ethno-culturally diverse context of China. These studies are also typically vague about their participants' ethnic or cultural backgrounds, simply assuming that Confucianism is the representative philosophy or way of life for all Chinese people (e.g. Xie et al. 2021; Xie et al. 2021).

We challenge this research bias by investigating different interpretations of the Confucian tradition (Bell 2010; Z. Wu 2016) in contemporary Chinese society through two sources. First, we examine the PRC school curriculum through officially approved textbooks, which represent the party-state's discourse on the Confucian tradition. As mentioned earlier, different interpretations of Confucianism are currently found in China (Bell 2010), and classics reading schools have recently emerged, which provide alternative instruction in the classical Confucian canon (Xu and Spruyt 2022; Wang 2022). However, state schooling and the national curriculum exert a tremendous influence because of their mandatory and universal status, and they thus constitute a key source for our study. Our second data source consists of interviews with a group of university students from non-Han or 'minority' religious backgrounds. Their experiences of learning about the Confucian tradition are currently under-researched in both Sinophone and Anglophone scholarship. A comparison of the two sources reveals the ideologies underlying the curricular treatment of Confucianism and the discrepancies in the discourses of the various actors in China's centre-margin power spectrum (Adamson and Morris 2014).



## Approach

We analysed the school textbooks for the six compulsory subjects of Chinese language, English language, political education, geography, history, and history and society at primary and secondary levels published between 2001 and 2016. A total of 217 volumes were collected, consisting of 123 from the People's Education Press (PEP), the largest educational publisher in China, and 94 from leading regional presses in southeast China. These textbooks were based on the PRC central government's cornerstone curriculum policy issued in 2001. This guides the curriculum objectives, structure, textbook development, management and assessment and covers education from early childhood up to senior secondary level (Chinese State Ministry of Education 2001). This national policy is theoretically still in force, although some school subjects have undergone significant reforms over the past two decades (particularly in the cases of History, Chinese language and Politics or 'Morals and Rule by Law'; see Yan and Vickers 2023).

The narratives of the Confucian tradition are predominantly concentrated in the curricula for political education, history-related subjects<sup>2</sup> and the Chinese language, whereas the English language and geography curricula only sporadically mention the tradition. The treatment of Confucianism varies according to the specific subject. For example, history-related subjects extensively cover the roles of Confucius and Confucian thought in Chinese history. Chinese language teaching primarily introduces traditional Confucian classics, such as the *Three Character Classic* (*Sanzijing*), *The Analects of Confucius* (*Lunyu*), *The Classic of Rites* (*Liji*) and *The Works of Mencius* (*Mengzi*). Our analysis of the texts involved first locating key terms, such as the names of central Confucian figures (e.g. Confucius, Mencius, Zhu Xi), Confucius' classical works and '*rujia*', the Chinese term for this tradition. We then applied critical discourse analysis to investigate the discursive practices through which Confucianism is interpreted in the curriculum texts.

The face-to-face interviews were conducted in 2017 with 37 university students from non-Han minority and/or religious backgrounds from two universities. One group consisted of non-Han minority students located in the northwestern region, where non-Han ethnic groups are typically more concentrated, and the other was a mainstream university located in the southeastern region that traditionally has a Han majority. Most students at both universities were from the local region, but as both recruit nationally, some students from other regions in China were included in the sample. Table 1 presents the backgrounds of the student participants. More students from the north-western university are represented in this study, reflecting the greater concentration of minority nationalities in that region. The participants came from 15 *minzu* groups, including those with the largest populations. Around 65% of the participants professed religious beliefs, including six Han-majority students and 18 non-Han minority students. Most of the participants (86%) were enrolled in a Chinese-only programme (*min kao han*), and the remaining 14% were in bilingual schools before entering the university. The latter were primarily Tibetan, Uyghur and Kazakh students from Tibet and Xinjiang. We applied the sampling strategy of 'maximum variation' (Miles, Huberman, and Saldana 2014) when recruiting participants from different ethnic and religious backgrounds. Factors such as gender and academic disciplines (sciences, social sciences or humanities) were also considered.



**Table 1** . Student participants' backgrounds ( $n = 37$ ).

|                                                                                                                                                                     | No. of students |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| <i>Geographical regions</i>                                                                                                                                         |                 |
| Northwest                                                                                                                                                           | 24              |
| Southeast                                                                                                                                                           | 13              |
| <i>Gender</i>                                                                                                                                                       |                 |
| Male                                                                                                                                                                | 21              |
| Female                                                                                                                                                              | 16              |
| <i>Backgrounds in pre-university education</i>                                                                                                                      |                 |
| Bilingual education ( <i>min kao min</i> )                                                                                                                          | 5               |
| Chinese-only curriculum ( <i>min kao han</i> )                                                                                                                      | 32              |
| <i>Academic backgrounds at university</i>                                                                                                                           |                 |
| Sciences                                                                                                                                                            | 16              |
| Social sciences and humanities                                                                                                                                      | 21              |
| <i>Religious beliefs and ethnicity</i>                                                                                                                              |                 |
| Buddhism (five Han, three Tibetan, one Bai, one Buyi, one Dong and one Hui student)                                                                                 | 12              |
| Islam (five Hui, two Uyghur, one Dongxiang and one Kazakh student)                                                                                                  | 9               |
| Christianity (one Han student)                                                                                                                                      | 1               |
| Other traditions (one Bai and one Zhuang student)                                                                                                                   | 2               |
| Ethnic minority students claiming no religious beliefs (four Tujia, two Zhuang, one Bai, one Dong, one Hui, one Manchu, one Miao, one Mongol and one Gelao student) | 13              |

All of the interviews were conducted in Mandarin Chinese, and the narratives presented below were translated. In the interviews, the researcher first asked general questions concerning the knowledge that the participants gained about Confucian ideas at primary and secondary school, and their general thoughts about the tradition and their experience of studying it. The researcher then asked open-ended questions concerning students' views on Confucianism, such as what they had learned about it through their primary and secondary schooling, how they perceived their teachers' attitudes towards the tradition, its role in a modern society and what they thought about its relationship with Chinese culture. We took a categorical-content approach to our narrative analysis of the interview data, in which 'separate utterances of the text are extracted, classified, and gathered into these categories/groups' (Lieblich, Tuval-Mashiach, and Zilber 1998, 13). The content categories for the two broader issues are given below, along with detailed examples from the narratives of the student participants.

### **Confucian tradition as a Chinese/Han construct in the curriculum narrative**

Our analysis of school textbooks for the six subjects reveals that the curricula generally present a positive account of the Confucian tradition. The textbooks represent Confucianism as the orthodoxy of imperial China (before 1912) and mention the criticisms it received from intellectual and political elites after the collapse of the Qing Empire. The curricula also leave space for students to evaluate the impact of the tradition and explore its contemporary legacies. For example, a history textbook unit entitled 'The rejuvenation of Chinese Culture' suggests that:

During China's long feudal era, Confucius had been highly respected, but in modern and contemporary times, he has become the most controversial historical figure. How should Confucius be evaluated? (PEP 2015a, 46)

The textbook thus appears to encourage students to reflect on the Confucian tradition, but this is not a major theme of the narrative. Much of the textbook content relating specifically to the Confucian tradition echoes the generally positive representation of Chinese culture, and two primary messages are notable. The first concerns the tendency to mobilise Confucian tradition as a cultural symbol of China for the non-Chinese world. This typically involves representing Confucianism as a philosophical school that, together with Buddhism and Daoism, comprises 'Chinese culture', with the Confucian tradition portrayed as the primary constituent.

The different subjects present various perspectives on Confucian tradition as a cultural symbol. In the integrated history and society subject, Confucius (551 BC–479 BC) and the Confucian School are cited as the prime originators of the traditional culture of the Chinese nation (PEP 2015b, 17) or of Chinese civilisation (Shanghai Education Press 2013, 18). Similarly, when explaining China's cultural exchanges with other countries, history textbooks state that the cultural sphere centred around Chinese culture is also called the 'Confucian cultural sphere' (*Rujia wenhuaquan*; East China Normal University Press 2015, 63). Chinese language textbooks portray the *Analects of Confucius* as one of the most important influences on the formation of Chinese culture and highlight its impact on various aspects of Chinese society, from politics and culture to education (PEP 2016a, 83–87). English language textbooks present Confucius as a great thinker, educator and cultural icon of the Chinese nation, and he is included in a gallery of heroes alongside Abraham Lincoln, Albert Einstein and Qian Xuesen<sup>3</sup> (PEP 2016b, 69).

The second message involves a portrayal of Han cultural superiority over non-Han people. The textbooks portray China as a multi-ethnic entity that has always incorporated a variety of cultures and religious practices, but the curriculum narrative clearly identifies Han tradition (itself represented as monolithic) as the core of Chinese culture and emphasises the cultural influence of Han over non-Han regimes. For example, when discussing dynastic regimes established by non-Han groups, the textbooks stress the willingness of the elite to study Confucian thought, as this extract illustrates:

Many kings of non-Han regimes encouraged agricultural development, followed the Han way in political governance, and promoted the learning of Confucianism and other Han Chinese's classics in cultural development. As a consequence, Han culture exerted profound influence over those regions. (East China Normal University Press 2015, 47)

Other notable examples of this emphasis are found in accounts of the Tibetan King Songtsen Gampo (c.617–650 AD) (PEP 2013a, 10), the Manchu Emperor Kangxi (1654–1722 AD) (PEP 2013, 13–16), and King Liu Yuan (?–310 AD) of the ethnic Xiongnu regime (East China Normal University Press 2015, 47). Perhaps the most prominent example relates to the Xianbei regime during the period of the Northern and Southern Dynasties (386 and 581 AD):

The Xianbei regime learned the rituals of the Han Chinese, respected Confucius and practised filial piety in governing the kingdom. (PEP 2015b, 81)

Under the leadership of Empress Dowager Feng<sup>4</sup>, the Northern Wei regime learned the more advanced culture of the Han. She encouraged the emperor to study the Confucian classics since his childhood, follow Confucian doctrines and rituals, and read other Chinese classics. (PEP 2014, 34)

Different versions of this account of how the Xianbei regime learned from the Han are found in history-related textbooks of various grades. The elites of the non-Han regime are depicted as basing reforms of their retrograde political and cultural practices on Confucian learning, thus integrating themselves into Chinese culture (on the portrayal of the relationship between Han and non-Han cultures, see also Yan and Vickers 2023).

School textbooks thus generally portray Confucian tradition as symbolising Chinese culture and embodying a cultural hierarchy that sets the Han majority above non-Han minorities. As the quoted extracts indicate, they do this primarily through allusions to ancient history; discussions of the role of Confucianism in modern Chinese society are limited.

### *Student views from the margins*

Interestingly, most of the students modestly stated that they had not developed a deep understanding of Confucianism, but our findings indicated otherwise. They stressed the difficulties and challenges that they faced when learning Confucianism; especially the language barrier for those whose home language is not Chinese. Further, Confucian classics are written in ancient Chinese, which even educated Han Chinese often struggle to comprehend.

The students' narratives detail their varied ethno-religious backgrounds and complex learning experiences and reveal how they view Confucianism in the culturally diverse Chinese society. First, they believed that the Confucian tradition is only one aspect of Chinese culture and that it can be interpreted in different ways, and second, many expressed the view that the Confucian tradition can benefit from interaction with other cultures.

### *Confucian tradition as one culture subject to differing interpretations*

The student participants generally viewed China as a culturally plural entity, in which Confucianism is an important component. However, it is only one cultural element amongst many, and others are also socially significant. Most students (around 86%) expressed the view that Chinese culture should be open and tolerant and should encompass diversity, with different cultural elements sometimes underpinning contradictory ethical standpoints. This view of Confucian tradition as one aspect of Chinese culture rather than its supreme embodiment was more common among those from the northwest and other largely non-Han regions, where students typically have more exposure to different cultures. For example, an ethnic Hui Muslim student from the northwest stressed that Chinese culture is a highly heterogeneous entity, involving a variety of traditions whose main ideas may conflict. He cited Confucianism and Daoism as examples, as both have strongly influenced the development of Chinese culture, but embody conflicting philosophies and worldviews. This Hui student majored in telecommunication at university and said that he preferred the Daoist worldview.

The students generally conceived Confucianism as an ethical tradition with a focus on personal morality and human relations. A male Hui Muslim student who grew up in Central China stated, 'Confucianism is a long-lasting culture that intends to teach people how to perfect themselves in various ways and how to manage human relations'. However, a notable proportion of the participants (around 43%) claimed that Confucian

culture was not inclusive but hierarchical and based on gender and/or social stratification. For example, when asked about her views on Confucianism, a female Tujia student who majored in politics stated, 'The Confucian culture is male-dominant, emphasising self-cultivation, family regulation, and state governance, and seldom values women's roles. I do not think that is right'. Students from both religious and non-religious and Han and non-Han backgrounds thought that the Confucian tradition embodied a patriarchal culture. Students professing religious faith appeared to show particular concern about the hierarchical orientation of Confucian tradition. For example, one male Buddhist Han student viewed the Confucian tradition as the mainstream culture of the elite of imperial China, saying, 'Confucius' benevolence is not inclusive, but hierarchical. Originally, Confucianism was designed to persuade the masses subjugate themselves to the ruling class'. The student converted to Buddhism in junior secondary school, largely because of his grandparents' influence, and studied social sciences.

The students' views on whether Confucian culture was still alive or relevant in China today also varied. Two thirds of the student participants affirmed that contemporary Chinese society evinces the strong influence of Confucian culture. They felt that Confucianism was deeply rooted in society or that they could discern some of its elements in the broader environment (particularly in government propaganda). The remaining third, all of whom were Buddhists or Muslims from various backgrounds ('minority' and Han), expressed doubts about whether Confucian culture was still alive or relevant, as they could not discern its influence in their surroundings.

### *Confucian tradition as one worldview requiring reflexivity*

The second theme emerging from the interview data was that the students understood the Confucian tradition as representing a particular worldview and outlook on life (such as a focus on relationships amongst humans, to the virtual exclusion of other creatures, the natural environment and the spiritual world) and as promoting certain values (notably personal morality, patriarchy and success in the pursuit of careers in state service). This group of students did not, however, completely reject the value of Confucianism. They understood it as a time-honoured tradition and recognised the government's efforts to promote it as the central ethical benchmark for Chinese society today. More than half of the student participants cited aspects of Confucianism they considered beneficial, mainly relating to teachings on personal morality. Drawing on their own lived experience and cultural or religious identities, they expressed varying ideas concerning the proper relationship between Confucian worldview and other cultural outlooks. Many believed that Confucianism could be enriched or improved through greater reflection on cultural differences. For example, a Christian Han majority student stated that Confucianism generally offered a monolithic worldview but that society should allow its members to make different choices and respect diversity. Asked what she thought of Confucianism, this journalism major student said:

Confucianism expects people to pursue one particular way of life, to succeed in official careers. Yet, in modern society, people have different careers and pursuits. Society should support pluralism, as the world is plural in nature.

This student grew up in the northwest and converted to Christianity with her mother when she was young. When growing up, she clearly experienced pressure as a member

of a cultural minority group that reinforced her conviction of the importance of respecting diverse choices and values.

Students critical of Confucianism frequently cited two points in particular. First, many noted that Confucianism is primarily focused on human beings rather than on the non-human world. This view was particularly common among Tibetan and Muslim students, whose cultural identity tends to be especially closely intertwined with religious faith. They thought that the Confucian worldview overemphasises the human domain and lacks a grasp of, or concern for, the natural environment. For example, a female Tibetan student majoring in social sciences stated that the Confucian tradition emphasises care for human beings but rarely considers other creatures in the world. It thus contrasted sharply with her Tibetan Buddhist beliefs, which, she said, mandated respect for all forms of life (including both human and non-human creatures) and promoted equality among all living beings.

Ignorance of people's inner lives and spirituality was another critical reflection on the Confucian tradition that was expressed especially by students who professed religious beliefs. One Muslim student of the Dongxiang *minzu* (from the northwest) noted the narrow scope of the Confucian outlook by comparison with his own religious worldview. He grew up in a rural community where traditional cultural practices were generally preserved, and compared with other Muslim students he had more opportunities to learn about Islam. At university, he majored in Chinese language and literature and thus became relatively familiar with Confucian classics and thought. He stressed the differences between the Confucian tradition and Islam. For example, he pointed out that Confucian wisdom is generally concerned with social relations amongst human beings, whereas religion explains fundamental issues about life itself, and offers a much broader worldview:

Religion can tell us much more about the world, for example, its origin, but Confucianism focuses primarily on social relations and informs how to be a person and maybe also how to live. Compared with religion, Confucianism does not elucidate people's experiences from birth to death and cannot provide a complete worldview.

In this student's opinion, Islam and the Confucian tradition share some commonalities, as both intend to teach people to be benevolent, but he averred that he could learn more about the world through Islam. A similar narrative about the lack of concern for spirituality in the Confucian tradition was expressed by a Buddhist Han student who grew up in central China and majored in journalism. Asked about the differences between Buddhist and Confucian traditions, he said:

Confucianism tends to emphasise moral constraints on people, while Buddhism can empower people to liberate their souls from sorts of pressure. Confucianism does not seem to hold such power.

The students from non-Han *minzu* backgrounds or religious communities thus frequently reflected on what they learnt about the Confucian tradition in the light of their own cultural outlook and experience. This contrasts sharply with the portrayal of Confucianism in the school curriculum, which does not encourage critical reflection on this or other features of Chinese tradition that today enjoy the stamp of CCP approval.

## Conclusion

We have examined the Confucian revival in China's diverse ethno-religious landscape, contrasting the depiction of Confucianism as 'official knowledge' (Apple 2000) with the views of a group of minority and/or religious students, representing communities who are generally marginalised within contemporary Chinese society. These two sources of data suggest a nuanced picture of the politics of Confucianism in the culturally diverse context of China today. The findings clearly illustrate both the importance for culturally marginalised students of critically reflecting on the status and meaning of Confucian thought, and the failure of school curricula to provide space for such critical reflection.

There is thus a clear disconnect between the official discourse of government-sponsored Confucian education, as channeled through school textbooks, and the critical student voices elicited through our interviews. Whereas the textbooks present Confucianism as the epitome of Chineseness, universally accepted as such both by Chinese citizens and foreigners, these students from culturally marginalised communities voiced definite criticisms of Confucian tradition, stressing its status as just one amongst a number of ethical outlooks or frameworks available to Chinese people. To some extent, this conclusion aligns with other studies that indicate that the influence of Confucianism amongst Chinese students more generally is fragmented and limited. For example, Xie, et al (2021, 97) argue that 'Confucianism is no longer a living historical representation that is connected to many aspects of social and political life and no longer mobilised as a regulative framework for understanding and managing new challenges to society as a whole'. Like most previous studies, that paper does not specify the *minzu* or religion of participants, with its findings mainly drawn from the Han majority but assumed to apply to all. By focusing on students from minority and religious backgrounds, our study takes the debate one step further. When critically examining the nature and roles of Confucian tradition in Chinese society and their lived experiences, these students suggest that, especially amongst these culturally marginalised groups, there is – or has been – a pushback against the official promotion of Confucianism as an emblem of monolithic Chineseness.

The representation of the Confucian tradition in the textbooks reveals the irony of monocultural education in a culturally diverse society. State-sponsored nationalism is directed, implicitly or explicitly, not only against foreign, and particularly Western, forces but also against diversity and pluralism within the national borders. The Confucian revival, in so far as it is associated with an increasingly essentialist and Han-centric conceptualisation of Chinese identity, further marginalises minority groups. Although the 'official knowledge' embodied in textbooks does include some differing views (for example, sometimes acknowledging the multi-ethnic reality of China, past and present), it does so in such a way as to reinforce assumptions of hierarchical relations between a Chinese civilisational centre and a cultural or territorial periphery. Our analysis of textbooks and interviews suggests that students are provided with limited opportunities to contemplate more cosmopolitan interpretations of Confucianism, as discussed in some studies (e.g. X. Chen 2020; Ivanhoe 2014). The curriculum, especially for subjects such as History, Morals and Politics, generally portrays non-Han *minzu* as recipients of wisdom and knowledge bestowed by the advanced, enlightened Han (Vickers 2015). The dominant official version of Confucianism, presenting it as the core of a monolithic

Han culture to be revered and imitated by all lesser *minzu* (Mullaney et al. 2012), thus tends to stoke cultural division and alienation.

The students interviewed for this study voiced their alternative understanding of the Confucian tradition and its role in Chinese society, stressing the necessity of critically reflecting on this tradition from the viewpoints of other cultures. This and other findings of the study underline the need for a paradigm shift in Chinese education: towards a more multicultural and inclusive approach to education in general and teaching of Confucianism in particular. However, political and educational developments in China since we conducted research for this study in 2017 have pointed in the opposite direction: towards a more nationalist, assimilationist, and Han-centric approach (Leibold and Dorjee 2023; Yan and Vickers 2023). Xi Jinping's selective reintroduction of Marxist orthodoxy, along with tightening constraints on academic freedom, have arguably stifled the revival of Confucianism as a spontaneous, 'living' tradition, previously indicated by the rise of semi-independent Confucian academies and the National Learning fever in the early 2000s (Bell 2023). What remains is the government-sponsored campaign for 'outstanding traditional Chinese culture', which renders Confucianism more thoroughly filtered and co-opted than ever before; as well as a thriving tendency in Anglophone scholarship to channel and promote that politically sanctioned version of Chinese tradition (e.g. Bell 2023; Tan and La Londe 2023). Heightened surveillance and control also cast a shadow over future research in this area. As noted by Leibold and Dorjee (2023) and Chen (2023) in this special issue, it is increasingly challenging to conduct fieldwork in mainland China today. We certainly hope that much-needed critical studies remain feasible, for the sake of continuing the conversation about the Confucian tradition within China and beyond.

## Notes

1. For an explanation of our preference here for the term 'nationality', see the editorial essay for this special issue of *Comparative Education* (60:1) by Vickers and Chen.
2. The textbooks in the history-related subjects collected in this study cover two curricula. The first is the independent subject of history taught in junior and senior secondary school, which has a long history in the PRC's school curriculum structure. The second curriculum, the integrated subject of history and society, was implemented at the junior secondary level as part of an initiative for developing the integrated curriculum implemented over the past two decades. That subject first originated in 2004 as an experiment by the Chinese Ministry of Education and was then added to the school system nationwide.
3. Qian Xuesen (also spelled Tsien Hsue-shen, 1911–2009) was a prominent scientist and is widely regarded as the 'father of Chinese aerospace'.
4. Empress Dowager Feng was the scion of the ruling family of a non-Han (Northern Yan) regime.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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